

Fashion & Appearance

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NOUNS

outfit

a set of clothes worn together

She wore a bright yellow outfit to the party.

refund

money given back for a returned item

I'd like to return these shoes, please. Would you prefer a refund or store credit?

wardrobe

all the clothes that a person owns

My wardrobe is mostly black and grey.

hand-me-down

a piece of clothing passed on from someone else, usually an older sibling

Most of my clothes as a kid were hand-me-downs from my brother.

ADJECTIVES

fashionable

popular and stylish at a particular time

Those trainers are really fashionable right now.

scruffy

untidy or shabby in appearance

He turned up looking scruffy in an old T-shirt.

underdressed

wearing clothes that are too casual for an occasion

I felt underdressed in jeans when everyone else wore suits.

tailored

cut and shaped to fit a particular person's body closely

He wore a beautifully tailored suit to the interview.

dishevelled

very messy and untidy in appearance, especially hair or clothes

He turned up looking dishevelled, like he hadn't slept.

flamboyant

confident, stylish, and noticeably showy

He's known for his flamboyant suits in bold colours.

casual

relaxed and informal in style

The office has a casual dress code on Fridays.

smart-casual

neat and stylish but not fully formal

The invitation said smart-casual, so I wore chinos and a shirt.

overdressed

wearing clothes that are too formal for an occasion

I was worried about being overdressed for a barbecue.

flattering

making someone look more attractive

That colour is really flattering on you.

understated

elegant in a subtle, not showy, way

She favours an understated style rather than anything flashy or over-the-top.

sartorial

relating to clothes or style of dress

Critics praised the actor's sartorial choices on the red carpet.

impeccable

(of dress or appearance) perfect, without any fault
His appearance was impeccable, right down to his polished shoes.

threadbare

(of fabric or clothing) worn so thin that the threads show through
He kept wearing that threadbare old cardigan, even though it was falling apart at the elbows.

VERBS

exchange

to swap a bought item for a different size, colour, or style
Can I exchange this? It's a bit too big.

accessorise

to add items such as jewellery or a bag to complete an outfit
She accessorised the plain dress with a bold necklace.

coordinate

to choose clothes or colours that go well together
He always coordinates his tie with his shirt.

PHRASAL VERBS

try on

to put on a piece of clothing to check the size or look
Can I try this jacket on before I buy it?

dress up

to wear smart or formal clothes, especially for a special occasion
We're dressing up for the wedding on Saturday.

dress down

to wear more casual clothes than usual
Most people dress down on Fridays here.

go with

(of clothes or colours) to look good together; to match
Do these shoes go with this dress?

stand out

to be easily noticed because of being different
That red coat really makes her stand out in a crowd.

pull off

to wear something successfully, even if it's unusual or bold
Not everyone can pull off bright orange trousers.

take back

to return a purchased item to the shop
I need to take these trousers back. They're the wrong size.

COLLOCATIONS

a good fit

clothing that matches someone's size and shape well
The jacket was a good fit through the shoulders.

first impression

the opinion formed of someone the first time you see or meet them
He wore his best suit to the interview, wanting to make a good first impression.

dress code

the rules about what clothing is acceptable in a particular place
What's the dress code for the interview?

wardrobe staple

a basic item of clothing worn often that goes with almost everything
A white shirt is a wardrobe staple.

business casual

a style of dress that is smart but not as formal as a suit

The email said business casual, so I left the tie at home.

fast fashion

cheaply made clothing produced quickly to follow current trends

Fast fashion is convenient, but the quality rarely lasts.

store credit

an amount a shop lets you spend later instead of giving cash back

They didn't have my size, so I ended up with store credit instead of cash back.

cost per wear

the value of a garment measured by its price divided by how many times it's worn

A good coat has a low cost per wear if you keep it for years.

frugal chic

a stylish or fashionable way of living that values spending less money and avoiding waste, often by buying secondhand items or making things yourself

Charity shop finds are at the heart of the frugal chic look.

statement piece

an eye-catching item of clothing or jewellery meant to draw attention

The red coat was definitely a statement piece.

wear and tear

the gradual damage caused by ordinary use over time

The jacket shows some wear and tear after years of daily use.

capsule wardrobe

a small collection of versatile clothes that can be mixed and matched

She built a capsule wardrobe of about thirty pieces she could wear all year.

signature look

a style so closely associated with someone that it defines their public image

The bow tie became his signature look.

IDIOMS

look the part

to have the appearance appropriate for a role or occasion

In that suit, he really looks the part.

make do and mend

to manage with what you already have and repair things rather than replace them

Rather than buy new clothes every season, some people prefer to make do and mend with what they already own.

dress to impress

to wear smart or attractive clothing in order to be noticed and admired

Everyone dressed to impress at the launch party.

dressed to the nines

wearing extremely smart or elaborate clothes for an occasion

They turned up dressed to the nines for the gala.

SET PHRASES

it suits you

used to say that clothing or a colour looks good on someone

Try the green one. It really suits you.

MODERN SLANG

kicks

trainers, especially fashionable or expensive ones
(informal)

*Check out my new kicks. I only bought them
yesterday.*

threads

clothes, especially fashionable ones (informal)

Nice threads! Where did you get that jacket?